Setting Up Your Development Environment

The day-to-day business of writing Rails programs is pretty straightforward. Everyone works differently; here's how we work.

The Command Line

We do a lot of work at the command line. Although an increasing number of GUI tools help generate and manage a Rails application, we find the command line is still the most powerful place to be. It's worth spending a little while getting familiar with the command line on your operating system. Find out how to use it to edit commands that you're typing, how to search for and edit previous commands, and how to complete the names of files and commands as you type.

So-called tab completion is standard on Unix shells such as bash and zsh. It allows you to type the first few characters of a filename, hit `Tab`, and have the shell look for and complete the name based on matching files.

Version Control

We keep all our work in a version control system (currently Git). We make a point of checking a new Rails project into Git when we create it and committing changes once we've passed the tests. We normally commit to the repository many times an hour.

If you're not familiar with Git, don't worry, because this book will introduce you to the few commands that you'll need to follow along with the application being developed. If you ever need it, extensive documentation is available online.[24]

If you're working on a Rails project with other people, consider setting up a continuous integration (CI) system. When anyone checks in changes, the CI system will check out a fresh copy of the application and run all the tests. It's a common way to ensure that accidental breakages get immediate attention. You can also set up your CI system so that your customers can use it to play with the